

Strategic Designer Starter Kit

Everything a new designer needs to start thinking and working like a strategist, not just a software operator.

WHO THIS IS FOR

Designers early in their careers — self-taught or freshly trained — who can already use the software but want to start thinking like the strategic designers who get hired for judgment, not just execution speed.

HOW TO USE IT

This kit bundles four short tools in one document: a mindset shift, a five-question filter, a vocabulary reference, and a 30-day practice plan. Work through them in order, then keep the vocabulary and filter close at hand for every project after.

PART 1 — THE MINDSET SHIFT

There are two kinds of designers: those who make things look good, and those who make things work. The first group is replaceable by the next person who learns the same software. The second group gets kept, promoted, and paid more — because they're solving business problems, and the visuals are just the proof of the thinking.

Strategic design isn't a more advanced style. It's a different question asked before every project: not "what looks good here?" but "what does this need to do, and for whom?" Everything in this kit is built to make that question automatic.

THE SHIFT, IN PRACTICE

Before: a client asks for a flyer, you make three colorful options and let them pick. After: you ask what the flyer needs to accomplish, who reads it, and where — then design the one option that actually does that job.

PART 2 — THE FIVE-QUESTION FILTER

Run every brief through these before opening design software. If you can't answer all five, you don't have a brief yet — you have a request.

1. Who is this actually for — one real person, not a category?
2. What should it make them think, feel, or do?
3. Where will they encounter it, and in what state of attention?
4. What's the one thing it absolutely must communicate, if nothing else lands?
5. How will anyone know if it worked?

Write these on a sticky note on your monitor until asking them is automatic. Most design mistakes trace back to skipping one of these five.

PART 3 — VOCABULARY EVERY STRATEGIC DESIGNER SHOULD OWN

Being able to name these concepts is what lets you discuss design with a client or a boardroom, not just show them options.

POSITIONING

Where a brand sits in the customer's mind, relative to alternatives.

HIERARCHY

The order in which a viewer's eye is guided through information.

WHITESPACE

Empty space used deliberately to create focus, not "wasted" space to fill.

BRAND VOICE

The consistent personality a brand communicates in words, independent of visuals.

SCOPE

The exact, agreed boundaries of a project — what's included, and what isn't.

PART 4 — 30-DAY PRACTICE PLAN

A short structured routine to build strategic habits without needing a live client project.

DAYS 1–7

Pick 5 brands you use often. For each, write their positioning statement from memory — then check it against what they actually say about themselves.

DAYS 8–14

Redesign one piece of your own past work using the five-question filter first. Compare the outcome to the original.

DAYS 15–21

Critique 3 pieces of design you encounter in daily life (a receipt, a billboard, an app screen) using the vocabulary from Part 3.

DAYS 22–30

Take on one small real project — for a friend, a local business, or pro bono — and run the full process: filter, brief, design, review.

NEXT STEPS

Strategic thinking is a habit built through repetition, not a switch you flip after one article. Revisit this kit every few months — the five-question filter especially tends to get skipped again once work gets busy. That's exactly when it matters most.